

Corp Governance and Agency Prob

Investment vs Financing Decisions

- **Investment Decision:** How to allocate capital to long-term assets (tangible/intangible assets)
- Also known as **Capital Budgeting Decision** or **Capital Expenditure (CAPEX) Decision**
- Examples of investment decisions: launching a new product, expanding into a new market, acquiring another company, investing in research and development
- **Tangible assets:** physical assets used in operations.
- **Intangible assets:** non-physical assets that provide long-term value.
- Examples of tangible assets : machinery, buildings, land
- Examples of intangible assets: patents, trademarks, copyrights, goodwill
- **Real assets:** physical assets used in operations (e.g. machinery, buildings, land)
- **Financial assets:** financial instruments that represent a claim on future cash flows (e.g. stocks, bonds, derivatives)

- **Financing Decision:** How to raise capital to fund long-term investments
- Also known as **Capital Structure Decision**
- Mixture of debt and equity financing
- Debt financing: borrowing money from external sources (e.g. banks, bondholders) with the obligation to repay with interest
- Equity financing: issuing shares of stock to investors in exchange for ownership stake in the company

Corporation

- A business organised as a separate legal entity owned by shareholders
- Shareholders elect a board of directors, who appoints managers to run the company and monitor their performance
- Separation of ownership and control.
- **(Permanence):** Corporation continues to exist even if ownership changes
- **(Limited Liability):** The owners of a corporation are not personally liable for its obligations. Shareholders are only liable for the amount they invested in the company.
- **Types of Corporations:**
 - **Public Corporation:** owned by a large number of shareholders and traded on public stock exchanges
 - **Private Corporation:** owned by a small group of shareholders and not traded on public stock exchanges
- **Types of Business Organisations:**
 - **Sole Proprietorship:** owned and operated by a single individual
 - **Partnership:** owned and operated by two or more individuals who share profits and losses
 - **Corporation:** separate legal entity owned by shareholders
 - **Limited Liability Company (LLC):** hybrid structure that combines the benefits of a corporation and a

partnership. No double taxation, limited liability, flexible management structure.

- **Professional Corporation (PC):** for licensed professionals (e.g. doctors, lawyers, accountants). Limited liability for business debts, but not for professional malpractice (can be sued).

	Sole Proprietorship	Partnership	Corporation
Who owns the business?	The manager	Partners	Stockholders
Are managers and owners separate?	No	No	Usually
What is the owner's liability?	Unlimited	Unlimited	Limited
Are the owner and business taxed separately?	No	No	Yes

Financial Managers

- **Chief Financial Officer (CFO):** oversees the financial operations/policies of the company and corporate planning
- **Treasurer:** manages the company's cash and investments, raises capital, and manages banking relationships
- **Controller:** oversees the accounting and financial reporting functions of the company, ensures compliance with financial regulations and standards

Agency Problem

- **Goals of a Corporation:**
 - Shareholders desire wealth maximization. Maximizing the current market value of shareholder's investment in the company.
 - Why not profit maximization? Profit is a flow variable, while wealth is a stock variable. Profit does not account for the time value of money, risk, and cash flows. Earning manipulation to increase short-term profit may harm long-term wealth.
 - **Opportunity cost of capital:** minimum acceptable rate of return on capital investments by shareholders (set by investment alternatives in the financial markets)
- **Agency Problem:** conflict of interest between shareholders (principals) and managers (agents). Managers are agents of shareholders and are tempted to act in their own interests rather than maximizing shareholder value.
- Managers have constituencies called **stakeholders** (e.g. employees, customers, suppliers, creditors, government) whose interests may not align with shareholders.
- **Agency Costs:** Value lost from agency problems or from efforts to mitigate agency problems.
- **Solutions to Agency Problem:**
 - **Executive Compensation:** align manager's interests with shareholders. E.g. stock options, bonuses tied to performance metrics (e.g. stock price, earnings per share)
 - **Corporate Governance:** Systems of laws, regulations, policies, institutions, and corporate practices that protect shareholders and other investors.
 - **Elements of Good Corporate Governance:**
 - Legal requirements and regulations
 - Board of Directors: independent directors, committees (e.g. audit, compensation, nomination)
 - Activist shareholders: large shareholders who actively monitor and influence management
 - Takeovers: threat of takeover can discipline management (e.g. If you share price is undervalued,

another company may acquire you and replace management)

- Transparency and disclosure: accurate and timely financial reporting, disclosure of material information

Ethics of Maximising Shareholder Wealth

- Short selling: selling borrowed shares in the hope of buying them back at a lower price to make a profit. (Can lead to market manipulation)
- Corporate raiders: investors who acquire a large stake in a company to influence management and increase shareholder value.
- Tax avoidance: legal strategies to minimize tax liability (e.g. offshore accounts, tax shelters)

Platform Business Models

- **Linear Value Chain:** traditional business model where value is created through a series of sequential activities (e.g. Design —> Manufacture —> Sell —> Deliver)
- **Platform Business Model:** business model that creates value by facilitating exchanges between two or more interdependent groups (e.g. buyers and sellers, users and developers) (Producers —> Platform <— Consumers)
- Examples: Uber, Airbnb, Amazon, Facebook, Google

Types of Platforms:

- **Product Platforms:** provide a foundation for creating and distributing products or services with improvements over time (e.g. iPhone, Tesla)
- **Transaction Platforms:** facilitate exchanges between buyers and sellers (e.g. eBay, Uber, Airbnb)
- **Innovation Platforms:** provide a foundation for third-party developers to create complementary products or services (e.g. iOS, Android, Windows)
- **Orthogonal Platforms:** Products or services that are based on the sale of different services of two groups of customers who do not come into contact with each other (e.g. newspaper advertising [client as a target], data brokers [client as a source])
- **Hybrid/Integrated Platforms:** combine elements of transaction and innovation platforms (e.g. Amazon, Google)

Advantages of Platform Business Models:

- No gatekeepers: anyone can participate as a producer or consumer. Consumers have more choices and producers have access to a larger market.
- New sources of value and supply: Asset owning is not necessary. Expansion is less risky. Sharing economy (Optimising the use of idle assets)
- Community feedback loops: users can provide feedback and ratings, which can improve the quality of products and services.
- Focus has shifted from broadcast to segmentation, and then to virality and social influence.
- From push to pull: consumers have more control over what they consume and how they consume it.
- From outbound to inbound: consumers actively seek out products and services that meet their needs and preferences.

Network Effects

Network effects occur when the value of a platform increases or decreases for users as more participants join the platform. (Two-sided, different from price effects and brand effects)

- **Positive same side:** When the value of the platform increases for users on the same side as more users join (e.g. social networks like Facebook, where more friends joining increases the value for existing users).
- **Negative same side:** When the value of the platform decreases for users on the same side as more users join (e.g. congestion effects in ride-sharing platforms, where too many drivers can reduce earnings per driver).
- **Positive cross side:** When the value of the platform increases for users on one side as more users join the other side (e.g. more sellers on eBay attract more buyers, and vice versa).
- **Negative cross side:** When the value of the platform decreases for users on one side as more users join the other side (e.g. too many advertisers on a platform like YouTube can reduce the user experience for viewers due to excessive ads).

Monetization

- Be careful with charging: Overcharging can drive users away, while undercharging can lead to unsustainable operations. Striking the right balance is crucial.
- Different types of platform monetization:
 - **Transactional Fees:** Both buyers and sellers are not discouraged. Platforms should still provide other value added benefits to prevent users/producers taking the activity outside the platform
 - **Access/Enhanced Access:** Charge producers for access to consumers or charge users for lowering barriers.
 - **Enhanced Curation:** Improve quality of interactions of those who pay a premium. (e.g. subscription for better vetting and screening of service providers)
- **Important principles:**
 - Avoid charging for value that users previously received for free.
 - Avoid reducing access to value that users have become accustomed to receiving.
 - Strive to create additional value that justifies the charge imposed.
 - Monetization strategies should be considered when making initial platform design choices.

Metrics

- **Metrics for Traditional Pipeline Model:**
 - Produce goods and services efficiently and sufficient for demand. (Operations)
 - Reach customers through proper channels at appropriate prices. (Marketing)
 - Generate adequate revenues to produce profits/value for investors (Finance)
 - E.g. Cash flow, inventory turns, operating income, gross margin, overhead, ROI
- *Platforms generate value through network effects*
- **Rate of interaction success** and factors that contribute to it.

- Quantifying success in generating desirable interactions amongst participants.
- **Startup Phase:**
 - Growth of active produces and consumers who are participating in large volumes of successful interactions
 - **Liquidity:** The ease with which participants can find and engage with counterparties for successful interactions on the platform. (Active usage, active users ÷ total users, new active users ÷ total active users)
 - **Matching Quality:** The degree to which the platform successfully connects participants with the right counterparties to fulfill their needs or preferences. (Percentage of search leading to interaction, correlation between interaction rate and long-term rate of activity)
 - **Trust:** The level of confidence participants have in the platform and its participants to ensure fair and reliable interactions. (Review system)
 - *Outcome based metrics, Metrics measuring commitment to ecosystem, Content creation metrics, Market access regardless of complete interaction*
- **Growth Phase:**
 - **Balance:** The platform's ability to maintain an appropriate ratio of producers to consumers to ensure a healthy ecosystem. (E.g. producer-to-consumer ratio, interaction success rate across different user groups)
 - **Side Switching Rate:** The frequency with which users switch roles between producers and consumers on the platform. (E.g. percentage of users who act as both producers and consumers within a given time period)
 - **Producer Side**
 - Frequency of producer participation, listings created, outcomes achieved
 - Interaction failure (initiated interactions that fall through)
 - Producer fraud (Failure to describe product offering accurately or deliver product)
 - Retention and Lifetime Value: Metrics that measure the ability of the platform to retain users over time and the long-term value generated by each user. (E.g. customer retention rate, average customer lifetime value, churn rate[lower the better])
 - **Consumer Side Side:**
 - Frequency of consumption, searches, and rate of conversion to sale.
 - Retention and Lifetime Value metrics as in a traditional business.
- **Maturity Phase:**
 - Driving innovation: platform must adapt to the needs of its users and changes in competitive and regulatory environment.
 - E.g Incorporate third-party feature that provides a large share of value enjoyed by users as own feature.

Future of Platform Revolution

- **Joining the revolution:** Information intensive industries; Industries with non-scalable gatekeepers; Highly fragmented industries (market aggregation); Industries characterised by extreme information assymetries.
- **Resist disruption:** Industries with high regulatory control, Industries with high failure costs (patient-doctor); Resource intensive industries